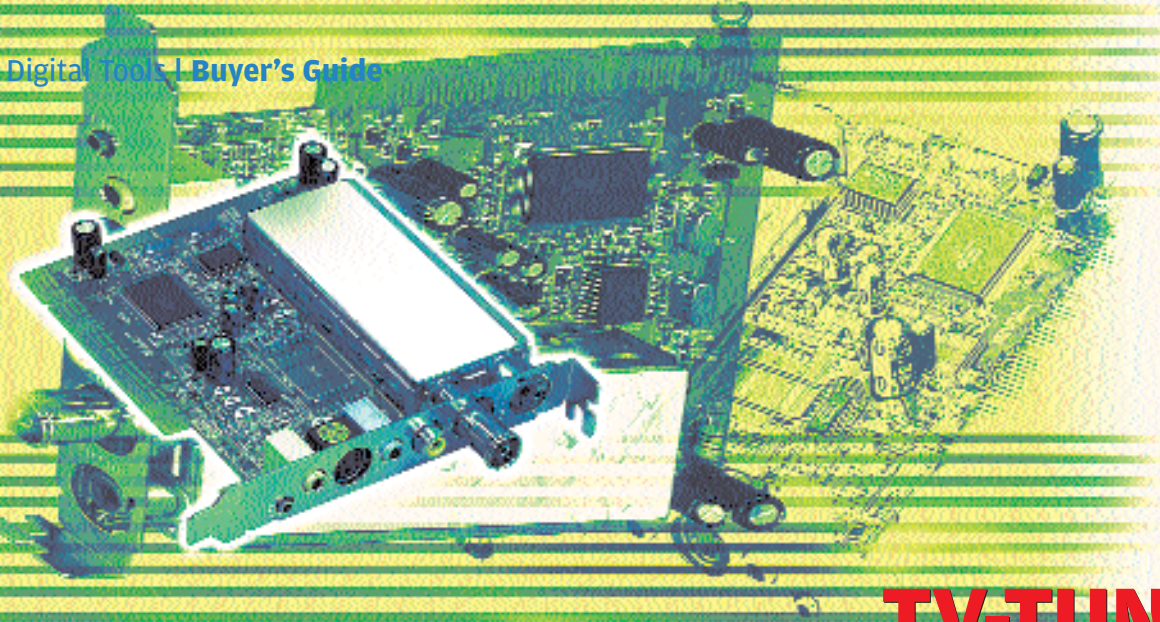




TV-TUNERS

Consumers expect their PCs to not just be a computing machine—they increasingly want it to perform as an entertainment device. The TV-Tuner is one of the prime components that add this functionality to the PC. Feature-packed TV-Tuners these days are giving TVs—or for that matter, standalone home theatres—a run for their money, given their extremely low prices.

There are three types of TV-Tuners available in the Indian market—internal PCI cards, external USB 2.0, and external set-top tuners. While the first two support recording in addition to viewing, the latter connects directly to a monitor, and does not support recording.

Questions to ask the dealer

Does the card come with a remote?

A TV-Tuner with a remote control will offer you the same convenience your TV remote offers you, and much more!

Does it have the 'Pause live TV' feature?

Many TV-Tuner cards allow you to pause live TV and continue where you left off!

Do I need to install any drivers for the TV-Tuner?

For set-top TV-Tuners, there is no need to install any drivers to be able to view TV.

Will it work at my place?

You should check the TV standards the TV-Tuner supports. It should support the PAL standard to be able to receive TV

broadcasts in India. If you happen to have encrypted cable services such as DTH, then you will need a digital TV-Tuner, which might not be available.

Does it feature FM radio?

FM radio is a feature is not worth missing, considering the little extra you'll have to pay.

What kind of driver support is there for the particular model of TV-Tuner you intend to buy?

Driver support is very important for a TV-Tuner in order to keep up with newer operating systems. Considering this aspect, buying a TV-Tuner card from a known brand is advisable.

Usage tips

Check for updated drivers for your model on the manufacturer's Web site because newer drivers generally contain many bug fixes.

In many cases, you might want to install third-party PVR software for better functionality and features than what comes bundled.

While capturing, background programs including the Anti-Virus program should be shut down, as these may affect the capture process.

Minimise the number of joints in the co-axial cable that brings the signal to your TV-Tuner card. Each joint causes a drop in the magnitude of the signal, dete-

riorating the quality of reception.

For optimal quality reception, select the proper TV system for your region in the PVR software.

Install third-party codecs such as DivX, because videos in this format offer good quality in smaller file sizes than formats such as MPEG 1 and 2.



Interesting Facts

In 1989-90, VCA frame-grabber cards were launched. These were capable of single-frame capture. Shortly afterwards, the IBM M-Motion Adapter was launched on the IBM PS/2 workstation, and this was later replaced by the IBM Action Media II card, which could capture video at 30 fps. It was in 1992 that Animation Studios (LifeView) and Hauppauge introduced the first TV-Tuner cards for the PC.

The Future

Microsoft's launch of the Windows Media Centre PC, of which the TV-Tuner is probably the most important component, signals the beginning of the transformation of the PC into a full-fledged entertainment centre.

Much of India can only receive analogue television signals, but with the appearance of digital encrypted services such as DTH starting to make their presence felt, this will change.

Many countries are already shifting to Digital Terrestrial Transmission. Digital TV-Tuners will become commonplace in the near future. ■

Points To Ponder

Will the TV-Tuner be able to capture TV broadcasts with decent quality?

This depends more on your system configuration and the video format in which you intend to capture than on the TV-Tuner itself. A 2.0 GHz processor, a 7200 rpm hard drive with enough free space, and 512 MB of RAM will generally yield good quality video capture. Capturing in MPEG2 is more taxing on the system than capturing in DivX or XVID.

What does a TV-Tuner need in order to capture content from any video source?

Check for ports such as S-Video and Composite In, which facilitate capture from video sources. Some TV-Tuners have a FireWire port, and so can even capture video from digital video sources. A TV-Tuner can capture video at a decent quality, but you should consider getting a dedicated capture card for professional-quality capture.